heart. The officers departing on the *Divnogorsk* told the KGB officer that some of the Cuban peasants had tears in their eyes when they learned about the departure of the Soviets. Colonel Ivan Sidorov remembered that some of the Cubans were disheartened by his men's departure, saying, "Our friends are leaving, but our enemies remain."[18]

What awaited the military at the ports did not lift their spirits either. With the ships still on their way to Cuba, they had to wait for days if not weeks to board. Lieutenant Polkovnikov of the 181st Missile Regiment recalled the utter chaos that he encountered upon arrival at the port of Mariel. "We unloaded our gear on the grounds of the port, which was completely full of our missile equipment, including some elements of R-14 rockets, disassembled IL-28 bombers, and so on." They had to wait a whole week to board a ship: "We slept out in the open, took shelter from downpours as best we could, fed the mosquitoes, recalled the moments of greatest tension, and ate dry rations."

It turned out that their ship, the *Pobeda* (Victory), which had brought the future Soviet defense minister Dmitry Yazov to Cuba, was waiting for them in Havana. It was only there that the tired and filthy soldiers were given an appropriate send-off, though not by the Cubans but by their own commanders. The commander of Polkovnikov's regiment, Colonel Kovalenko, addressed his men: "We stood on the cutting edge of history and honorably carried out the task assigned us—to defend revolutionary Cuba." Polkovnikov noticed the absence of Cuban officials or representatives of the armed forces of Cuba.[19]

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GENERAL IGOR STATSENKO RECEIVED HIS ORDER TO BEGIN dismantling the missile sites that he had spent so much time and effort constructing on the afternoon of October 28. He began to implement the order next morning. Three days later, on October 31, he reported to the visiting UN Secretary General, U Thant, that the work was all but finished. Indeed, the dismantling of the missiles was completed by the end of that day.